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carlin@nyc:~$ ./internship-review
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Beyond the Code

What NYC and the AI Era Taught Me

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Universal Processing · Summer 2026

\$ whoami



name	Carlin Hou
role	Software Engineering Intern
team	Universal Processing
current	New York City

// background

**My background
combines business and
information systems.**

I connect technical decisions with users,
operations, and company goals.

Taiwan → New York City: The environment changed quickly; my willingness to adapt did not.

My Best Work Starts Early

// why the early start

Morning energy goes to the work that needs the clearest thinking.

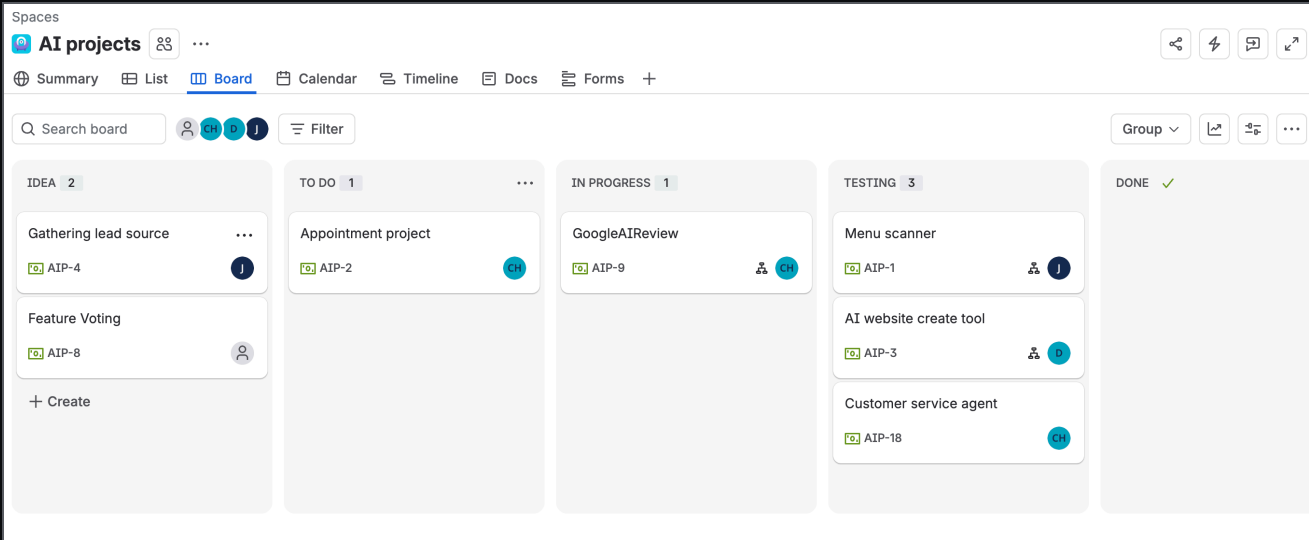
I'm usually in before 8:30—and often first at the office.

BEFORE 08:30	<code>sync()</code>	Taiwan handoff Email · chat · Jira · daily plan
MORNING	<code>focus()</code>	Deep work Demos · docs · architecture · code
RECURRING	<code>align()</code>	Team alignment Lewis (CTO) 1:1 · Taiwan engineers + PM weekly
LUNCH	<code>reset()</code>	Recharge Weekend meal prep · short nap
AFTERNOON	<code>verify()</code>	Close the loop QA · docs · code review · plan check

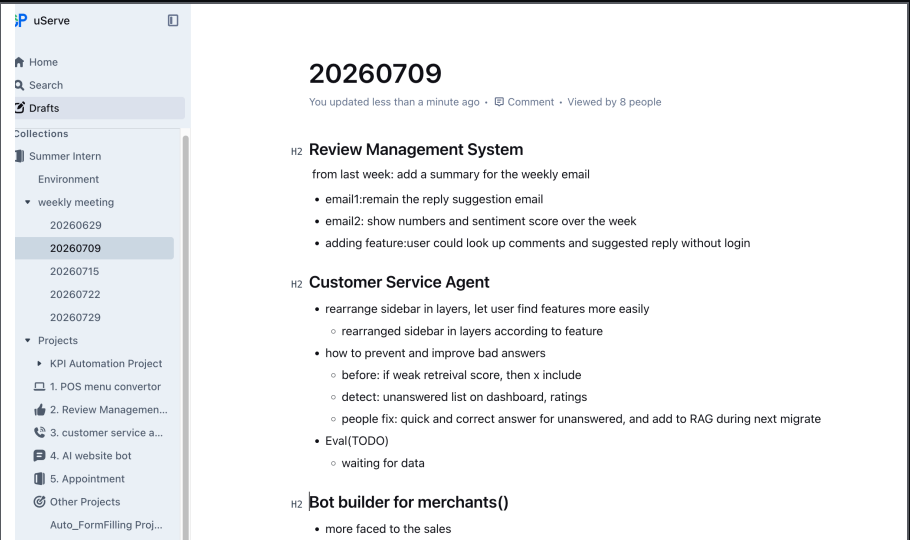
— Align early. Build deeply. Verify before leaving.

The Work Started Before the Code

// product loop



Jira board · requirements become visible, trackable work



Weekly notes · decisions, feedback, and next steps

Development starts with shared understanding.

Each Project Started With a Real Bottleneck

01	<code>respond()</code>	PROBLEM	Marketing manages Google and Yelp reviews across many merchant accounts.
	Merchant Review Dashboard	SOLUTION	One dashboard, AI replies, and owner approval for sensitive cases.

02	<code>support()</code>	PROBLEM	Payment issues can happen after hours, when support may miss a call.
	24/7 Support Assistant	SOLUTION	RAG chat answers first; phone intake routes a clearer case.

03 / MVP	<code>coordinate()</code>	PROBLEM	Many salon merchants still schedule appointments with paper and pen.
	Salon Booking Assistant	SOLUTION	One MVP for booking, staff, schedules, and resources.

— The goal: less waiting for merchants and less repetitive work for the team.

One Dashboard for Reviews Across Many Merchants

★ GBP Reply Manager

Manage reviews

How is any business doing on Google?

Search a business to see its Google rating and a clearly labeled snapshot of recent public reviews. Free, no sign-in.

Manage your reviews

Search

Suggestions update as you type.

Live link: replymanager.userve.io

```
// problem → solution → value
```

PROBLEM	Marketing manages Google and Yelp reviews across many merchant accounts.
SOLUTION	One dashboard tracks merchants; AI posts routine replies and routes negative cases to the owner.
VALUE	Fewer account switches, faster routine replies, and safer handling of sensitive reviews.

```
collect() → draft() → owner_check() → post()
```

CONTRIBUTION	Dashboard · merchant stats · AI replies · approval flow
NEXT	Revise with MKT feedback · prepare daily workflow

Support Problems Don't Wait for Office Hours

// problem → solution → value

PROBLEM Payment issues can happen at any hour; a missed call can mean lost sales.

SOLUTION RAG searches company documents first; phone intake clarifies and routes the issue.

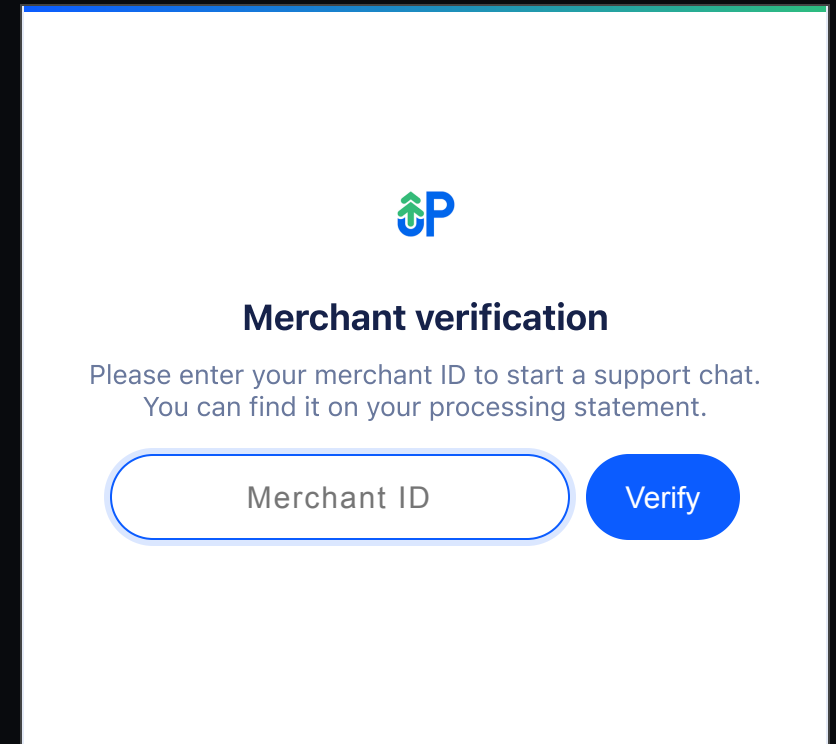
VALUE A path toward 24/7 first response, clearer cases, and faster document search.

question → retrieve(docs) → answer_or_escalate()

CONTRIBUTION Structured knowledge · RAG · phone intake · evaluation

NEXT CRM connection · more real support data

— The goal: merchants get a first response; support gets a clearer case.

A screenshot of a web interface for merchant verification. At the top center is a logo consisting of a green upward arrow and a blue 'P'. Below the logo is the heading 'Merchant verification' in bold. Underneath is a text prompt: 'Please enter your merchant ID to start a support chat. You can find it on your processing statement.' There are two input fields: a large, rounded rectangular box with a blue border containing the text 'Merchant ID', and a smaller, solid blue rounded button to its right containing the text 'Verify' in white.

Live link: csagent.userve.io

Replace Paper Scheduling With One Booking System

PROBLEM	Many salon merchants still manage appointments with paper and pen.	SOLUTION / MVP	Plan one system for chat, phone, appointments, staff, and resources.
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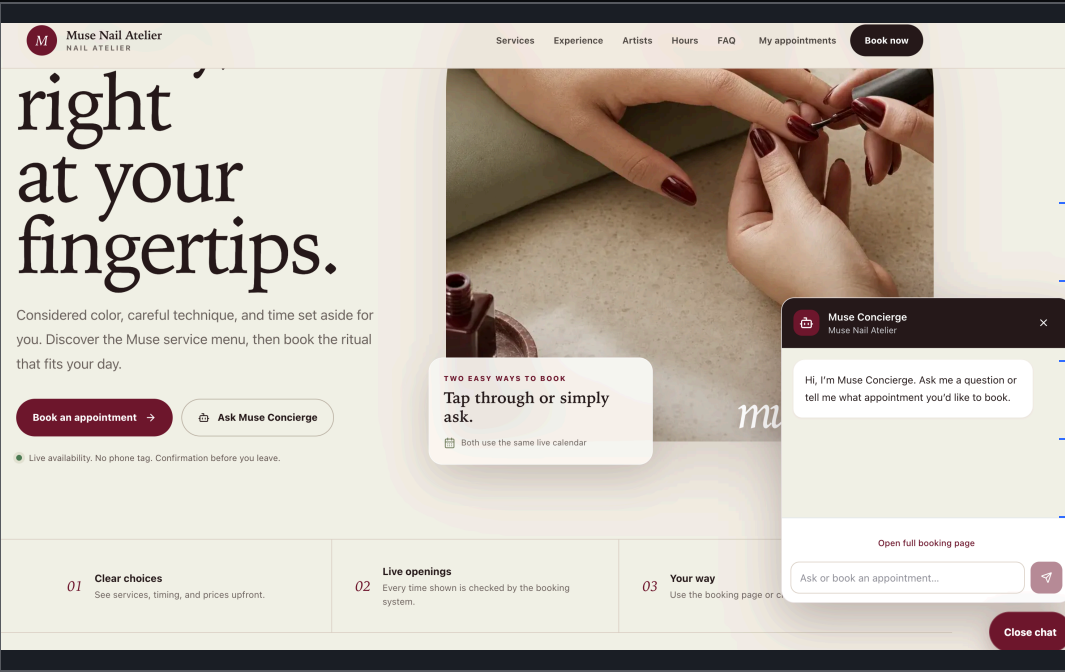
service.duration

employee.skills

staff.schedule

multiService[]

add0ns



The screenshot shows the Muse Nail Atelier website. The header includes the logo, navigation links (Services, Experience, Artists, Hours, FAQ, My appointments), and a 'Book now' button. The main content area features a large image of hands being manicured, with the text 'right at your fingertips.' and a description of the service. Below this is a 'Book an appointment' button and a 'Ask Muse Concierge' button. A chat overlay is visible on the right side of the page, with a message from 'Muse Concierge' and a 'Close chat' button. The footer contains three columns of text: '01 Clear choices', '02 Live openings', and '03 Your way'.

room

equipment

owner.admin

planned.chat

planned.phone

Two-week MVP: prove the scheduling rules before building the full system.

How My Use of AI Changed

v1.0

College

AI as a search tool

Samples + Stack Overflow.

v2.0

Internship in Taiwan

AI as a coding partner

Specific tasks. Limited context.

v3.0

New York City

AI inside a complete
product process

Specs. Steps. Review. Feedback.

— The developer's role is shifting from producing more code to making better decisions.

The Bottleneck Moved.

BEFORE	IN THE AI ERA
Writing code	Defining the right problem
Implementation speed	Clear requirements
Technical execution	Human judgment
Feature delivery	Product alignment
Individual output	Shared knowledge

— Speed creates value only when the team shares a clear destination.

This summer changed how I think
about building useful products.

**Still learning.
Still building.
Still halfway.**

With thanks to Taipei City, Universal Processing, the engineers, coworkers, and
interns who shaped this summer.

Thank you.

